


# The Introduction Section

## Penulisan Proposal (CCK4CAB2)

Course: Proposal Writing · Meeting 2 of 4 · Duration 100 minutes

# 01 The Job of the Introduction

What the section must achieve before the reader will grant it any patience.



**1. Set the stage**

Provide just enough background for the reader to understand the problem.

**2. State the problem**

Make the problem clear, real, and worth solving.

**3. Present the questions**

Show exactly what this study will answer.

**4. Explain the significance**

Why the answers matter — for knowledge, practice, or policy.

**5. Preview the approach**

Briefly note how the study will be done.

★ The introduction earns attention by showing relevance, clarity, and direction — in that order.

# What the Introduction Actually Does

## DEFINITION

The introduction is the section that turns a topic into a problem. It gives the reader enough context to understand the situation, evidence that a specific difficulty is real and unresolved, and a precise statement of what this study will do about it.




### It orients

The reader may know the field but not your context. The introduction supplies exactly the background needed — no more.

The field → Your context → Reader understands

### It justifies

It argues that a real gap exists and that answering it is worth someone's time, money, and permission.

Evidence of the gap → Worth doing → Worthy of resources

### It commits

By the last paragraph you have publicly promised what will be studied, with whom, and within what boundaries.

What will be studied | With whom | Within what boundaries

**Takeaway:** The introduction earns attention by showing relevance, clarity, and direction — in that order.

# The Introduction Is a Funnel

## SHAPE OF THE SECTION

It moves from a situation your reader already accepts to one question only your study will answer. Never the reverse.

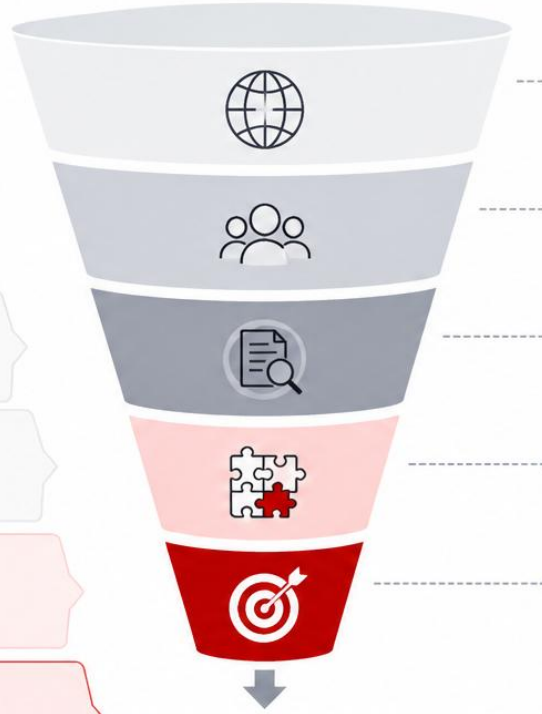
**1 THE FIELD**
The wider situation or phenomenon, established with citations.

**2 YOUR CONTEXT**
The specific setting, population, or practice you are concerned with.

**3 WHAT IS KNOWN**
What prior work has already established about that context.

**4 WHAT IS MISSING**
The gap: the question prior work leaves unanswered.

**5 THIS STUDY**
Your purpose, your questions, and the boundaries you set.



**Start broad**
(What's the big picture?)

**Narrow to your world**
(Where does it matter?)

**Build the foundation**
(What do we already know?)

**Reveal the gap**
(What don't we know?)

**State your focus**
(What will this study do?)

**ONE QUESTION.**
One study. Clear boundaries.

**TIP:** A reader should be able to point at the paragraph where each of these five levels begins.

# The Components and Their Jobs

## ANATOMY OF THE SECTION

| Component | What it must accomplish | Typical share |
|---|---|---|
| **Background of the study** | Establishes the situation and shows, with evidence, that a difficulty exists. | 40–50% |
| **Problem statement** | Names the specific gap or difficulty this study addresses. | 10–15% |
| **Research questions** | States precisely what will be answered, in answerable form. | 5–10% |
| **Objectives** | Restates the questions as actions the study will perform. | 5% |
| **Scope & delimitations** | Marks the boundaries you deliberately set, and why. | 5–10% |
| **Significance** | Explains who benefits from the answer and in what way. | 10% |
| **Definition of key terms** | Fixes the meaning of terms used throughout the proposal. | 5% |




**KEY IDEA:** Move your reader from broad and familiar to specific and necessary — so the final question feels both logical and urgent.

*Shares are indicative only; the order of components follows your institution's template.*

# A Classic Model: Creating a Research Space

## RHETORICAL STRUCTURE

Swales' CARS model describes the three moves almost every strong introduction makes, in this order.




### 1 MOVE 1
### Establish the territory



- Show the area matters
- Give necessary background
- Summarise prior work

> *"Asynchronous learning has become a standard delivery mode…"*

**Goal:** Get the reader to say "yes, this is important."

### 2 MOVE 2
### Establish a niche



- Indicate a gap or tension
- Question a prior finding
- Note an untested context

> *"However, little of this work examines first-year students…"*

**Goal:** Get the reader to see a gap worth filling.

### 3 MOVE 3
### Occupy the niche



- State your purpose
- Announce your questions
- Preview scope and value

> *"This study therefore examines how feedback timing relates to…"*

**Goal:** Get the reader to accept your place in that gap.

**Takeaway:** Move from what is known → to what is missing → to what your study will do about it.

# What the Reader Is Asking, Paragraph by Paragraph

## READER EXPECTATIONS

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | **What is this about?**<br>• Identify the topic and context. | Answered by the opening of the background — in the first two or three sentences, not on page three. |
| 2 | **Why should I care?**<br>• Understand the impact and relevance. | Answered by evidence of consequence: who is affected, and what happens if nothing is known. |
| 3 | **What is not yet known?**<br>• See the gap in current knowledge. | Answered by the gap: a specific, defensible statement of what prior work has left unresolved. |
| 4 | **What exactly will you do?**<br>• Know your purpose and questions. | Answered by the purpose statement and research questions, stated in one place and unambiguously. |
| 5 | **What are you not doing?**<br>• Understand the boundaries. | Answered by scope and delimitations, which protect you as much as they inform the reader. |

## THE READING JOURNEY

**Understand**
What is this about?

↓

**Value**
Why should I care?

↓

**Recognize the gap**
What is not yet known?

↓

**See the plan**
What exactly will you do?

↓

**Trust the boundaries**
What are you not doing?

**KEY IDEA:** Answer these questions early, clearly, and in order. | If a question is answered late, the reader assumes you do not know the answer either.

# 02

# Background of the Study

Building context from evidence rather than from assumption.



**Use evidence**

Rely on credible sources and data.

**Build context**

Connect findings to show the bigger picture.

**Create the need**

Show why the problem is worth solving now.

**From assumption**

*"It is likely that..."*

Weakens the case.

**From evidence**

*"Studies show that..."*

Strengthens the case.

# What the Background Must Achieve

## BACKGROUND

### Orient a non-specialist

Your examiner may not work in your exact area. Give the **minimum context** needed to follow the problem — and nothing decorative.

### Show the situation is real

Replace "nowadays it is very important" with data, documented practice, policy, or prior findings that a reader can **verifiable evidence**.



### Narrow toward your variables

Each paragraph should be **closer to your specific problem** than the one before it.

Broad field → Context → Focus → Your variables

### Open the door to the gap

By the final paragraph the reader should already sense **what is missing**, before you name it.

What is known → What is missing → Your study

**Remember:** Build context step by step, using evidence, so the reader is ready to see the gap your study will address.

# Where Background Evidence Comes From

**Strong backgrounds** are built on **credible**, **verifiable**, and **citable** sources.

## EVIDENCE

### Official statistics

Agency data, institutional records, census or ministry reports — **cite the release,** not a news summary of it.

**Examples:** BPS, UNESCO, WHO, Ministry of Education reports

### Prior empirical studies

Peer-reviewed findings that establish what is already observed in your area.

**Examples:** Journal articles, theses, conference papers

### Policy & regulation

Curricula, standards, laws, or institutional rules that define the situation you study.

**Examples:** National curriculum, laws, institutional guidelines

### Documented practice

Reports, audits, or field observations showing how things are actually done.

**Examples:** Program reports, audit reports, observation notes

### Theory

The conceptual account that explains why the phenomenon behaves as it does.

**Examples:** Models, frameworks, conceptual theories

### Not acceptable alone

Personal impression, unsourced blogs, generative-AI output, or "it is well known that…".

**Examples:** Anecdotes, opinion pieces, AI-generated text

Find credible sources → Read critically → Paraphrase accurately → Cite precisely

**Rule of thumb:** Every claim about the state of the world in your background carries a citation.

# The First Paragraph

Your first sentence should signal: **relevance**, **context**, and **credibility**.

## OPENINGS

The opening sentence sets the reader's expectation of your seriousness.
These two openings describe the same study.



### EMPTY OPENING

*"In this era of globalisation, technology is developing very rapidly. Everyone uses the internet nowadays. Therefore, the researcher is interested in studying online learning."*

Too broad, obvious, and lacks evidence.

**Weak start.**

### EVIDENCED OPENING

*"Asynchronous delivery has remained a permanent component of undergraduate teaching in many Indonesian universities since 2020 (Author, Year). Institutional data show that completion rates in fully asynchronous courses lag behind those in scheduled classes (Author, Year)."*

Specific, evidenced, and relevant.

**Strong start.**

### DO THIS

- Start with the situation in your context.
- Use evidence early (data, studies, reports, policy, etc.).
- Show the topic matters and is worth studying.

### DON'T DO THIS

- Don't start with a broad history or general facts.
- Don't define terms in the opening.
- Don't make claims you don't cite.

**Remember:** The first sentence earns the reader's trust—be specific, supported, and relevant from the start.

# Building the Background in Four Moves

## STRUCTURE

A workable default for a background of four to eight paragraphs.

### 1 Situate

Establish the wider phenomenon and why it matters, with sources a reader can check.



Purpose: Show the big picture and its importance.

### 2 Localise

Bring it to your setting, population, or institution. This is where most drafts stop too early.



Purpose: Connect the big picture to your specific context.

### 3 Summarise

State briefly what prior work has established here — a preview, not the literature review.



Purpose: Show what is already known and agreed.

### 4 Unsettle

Show the tension: findings conflict, contexts differ, or the question was never asked.



Purpose: Create the need for your study.

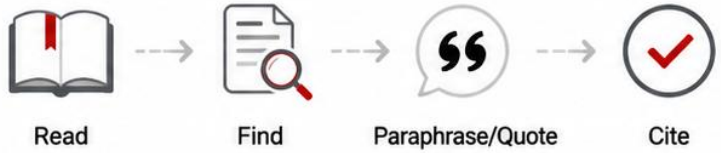



**Remember:** The last move hands the reader over to your problem statement. ***If it does not, the problem will feel like it arrived from nowhere.***

# Citing Inside the Background

## SOURCING

Good sourcing builds trust and shows exactly where your ideas come from.




**1 Cite what you read**

Never cite a source you know only from another author's summary. If you cannot access it, cite the source that quoted it, correctly.



**2 Balance recent and seminal**

Recent work shows the problem is live; foundational work shows you know where the ideas came from.



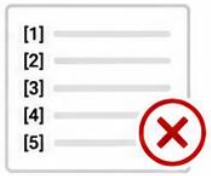

**3 Paraphrase by default**

Quote only when the exact wording carries meaning that a paraphrase would lose.



**4 One claim, one citation**

Do not stack five references after a general sentence to look thorough. Reviewers read it as padding.




**5 Match the required style**

APA, IEEE, Chicago — apply one consistently, including for in-text citations and secondary sources.




**6 Keep it in the background**

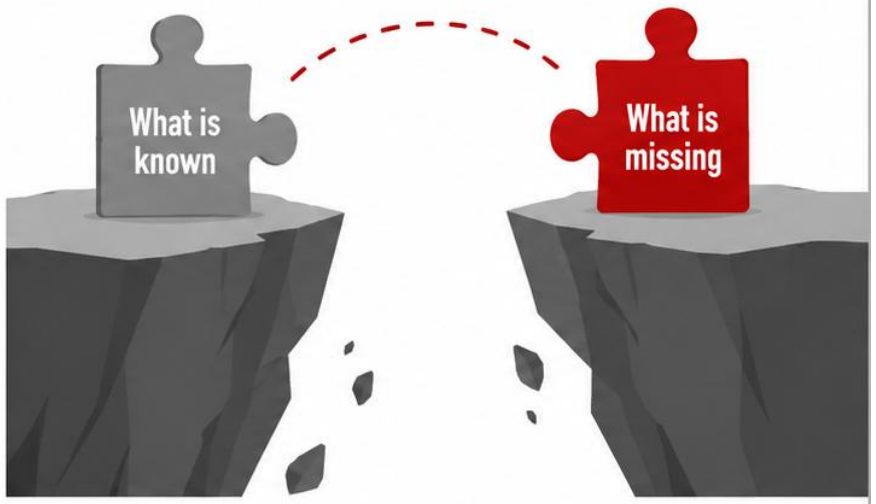
Detail belongs in the literature review. Here, cite only enough to establish the situation.



**Remember:** A citation that does not say what you claim it says is treated as a factual error, not a formatting slip.

# 03 The Problem Statement and the Gap

This section transforms the tension from your background into a clear, researchable problem and identifies the specific gap your study will address.




**Name the problem**
State the problem clearly in one or two sentences.

**Show the gap**
Explain **what is not yet** known or remains **unresolved**.

**Justify the need**
Explain why this **gap matters** for theory, practice, or policy.

**Lead to your study**
Close by pointing to the exact **focus** of your research.

**Remember:** The problem statement is not a topic. It is the specific issue your study will solve.

# What a Problem Statement Is

A good problem statement turns a broad topic into a specific, researchable issue.

**CORE OF THE SECTION**

The problem statement defines the exact issue your study will address.

## IT IS

- A statement of a **specific difficulty**, discrepancy, or unknown
- Grounded in **evidence** presented in the background
- Bounded to a **population, context,** and **period**
- Written so that a reader can **see what** an **answer would look like**
- Usually **one focused paragraph,** sometimes two

## IT IS NOT

- A **restatement** of your topic in longer words
- A description of your **method** or instrument
- A **list** of your research questions
- A statement that you **personally** find the topic interesting
- A complaint that "little research has been done" with **no evidence**

**GOOD PROBLEM STATEMENT (IT IS)**

*"First-year students in asynchronous courses at Indonesian universities experience lower completion rates than those in scheduled classes during the 2020–2024 period."*

VS.

**NOT A PROBLEM STATEMENT (IT IS NOT)**

*"This study discusses online learning in higher education and uses surveys to find out students' opinions about it."*

**Test:** Could someone **disagree** with your problem statement? If not, it is a **description, not a problem.**

# A Structure That Always Works

## THE FIVE-PART PROBLEM STATEMENT

Write one to three sentences for each part, in this order. Revise afterwards for flow.

**1 Ideal**
What should be happening, according to theory, policy, or standards.

**2 Reality**
What is actually happening, shown with evidence from the background.

**3 Gap**
The discrepancy, or what remains unknown about it, stated precisely.

**4 Consequence**
What it costs to leave this unresolved, and to whom.

**5 Response**
What this study will therefore do — one sentence, no method detail.

*Example questions*

- What should be happening?
- What is actually happening?
- What is the gap?
- What is at stake if it remains?
- What will this study do?

**Remember:** Most rejected problem statements contain parts 1, 2, and 5 — and quietly skip the gap and the consequence.
**Those two are the argument.**

# Six Kinds of Research Gap

## NAMING THE GAP

A research gap is what is still unknown, unclear, or unresolved — and worth studying.

Naming the gap clearly focuses your study and shows its value.

### 1 Knowledge gap

A relationship or phenomenon has simply **not been examined** yet.



**Example:** No studies have examined X.

### 2 Context or population gap

It has been examined, but **not in your setting**, culture, level, or sector.



**Example:** Studied in other countries, but not in Indonesia.

### 3 Methodological gap

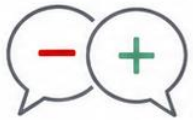
Prior work used designs that **could not answer** the question convincingly.



**Example:** Mostly surveys used, but the question needs qualitative insight.

### 4 Conflicting findings

Studies **disagree**, and the disagreement has not been resolved or explained.



**Example:** Results vary across studies with no clear reason.

### 5 Practice gap

What research recommends and what practitioners actually do have **diverged**.




**Example:** Recommended, but rarely implemented in real settings.

### 6 Theory application gap

An established theory has **not been tested** against this particular case.



**Example:** Theory X exists, but not tested in context Y.

**Remember:** Name which of these your gap is. “No one has studied this” is almost never true — and is easy for an examiner to disprove.

# One Problem, Two Statements

A strong problem statement shows the full chain: **situation → gap → why it matters → what this study will do.**

## WORKED EXAMPLE

### WEAK

*"Many students today take online courses and many of them do not finish. This is an interesting problem. Therefore the researcher wants to research student engagement in online learning."*

**Why it's weak:**

- No evidence
- No specific gap
- No consequence
- No clear response

### STRONGER — THE FIVE PARTS ARE VISIBLE

*"Course design standards assume that students in asynchronous courses receive feedback promptly enough to act on it (Author, Year). In practice, feedback in large first-year courses is often returned after the next task has begun (Author, Year). Although several studies link feedback quality to engagement, few examine feedback timing in asynchronous undergraduate settings, and none report evidence from Indonesian universities. As a result, institutions redesign these courses without knowing which element of feedback actually sustains engagement. This study therefore examines how feedback timing and peer interaction relate to engagement among first-year students in asynchronous courses."*

**Why it's stronger:**

- Evidence-based
- Names the specific gap
- States the consequence
- Ends with a clear response
- Focused and testable

## THE FIVE PARTS

1. **Ideal** — What should be happening, according to theory, policy, or standards.
2. **Reality** — What is actually happening, shown with evidence.
3. **Gap** — The discrepancy, or what remains unknown about it, stated precisely.
4. **Consequence** — What it costs to leave this unresolved, and to whom.
5. **Response** — What this study will therefore do — one sentence, no method detail.

**Remember:** Ideal → Reality → Gap → Consequence → Response. Five sentences, one paragraph, no method detail.

# Where Problem Statements Fail

Reviewers test this section first.
Avoid these mistakes.

## COMMON MISTAKES

Strong problem statements are specific, evidence-based, and consequential.

### 1 The topic is restated, not problematised

"This study is about digital literacy" tells the reader nothing that is at stake.




Focus on why it is a problem, not the topic.

### 2 The gap is asserted, not shown

Claiming a gap without citing the work you searched is the fastest way to be challenged in a defence.




Show the gap with evidence from your review.

### 3 No consequence is given

If nothing follows from the unknown, the reader has no reason to approve the study.




Explain what it costs to leave it unresolved.

### 4 The problem is too large

A problem that would take a research team five years cannot be your semester project.



Narrow it to your setting, period, and focus.

### 5 Method appears too early

Instruments and sampling belong in Chapter 3, not in the statement of the problem.



State the problem first, the method later.

### 6 Personal motivation stands in for evidence

"The researcher is interested in…" is not a reason for anyone else to care.



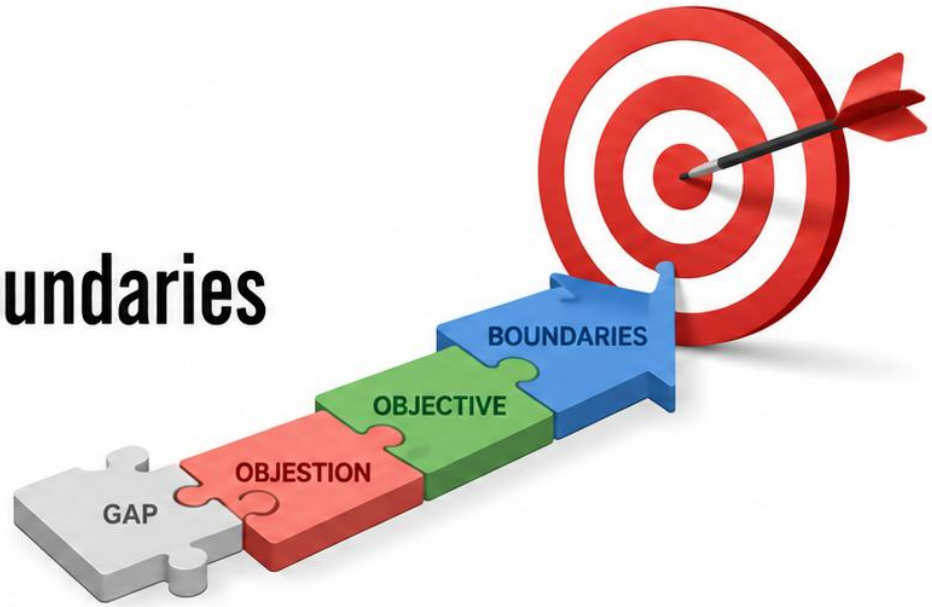
Use evidence, not personal interest.

**Quick check:** Does your statement show the five parts (Ideal → Reality → Gap → Consequence → Response) in one clear paragraph? If any part is missing, revise.

# 04

# Questions, Objectives, and Boundaries

Turning the gap into something you can actually answer.




## Questions

What are you asking? Convert the gap into a clear, researchable question.

## Objectives

What do you aim to achieve? State what this study will find or explain.

## Boundaries

What will and won't you cover? Define the scope, context, and limits of the study.

**Why it matters:** Clear questions, objectives, and boundaries make your study focused, feasible, and defensible.

# From Gap to Research Questions

## DERIVING THE QUESTIONS

Turn your problem into a clear question, then break it into focused, answerable parts.




**MAIN QUESTION**

**How are feedback timing and peer interaction related to student engagement in asynchronous first-year courses?**

**SUB-QUESTION 1**

**What patterns of feedback timing are reported by students in these courses?**

**Focus:** Describes how feedback timing occurs (e.g., early, late, same day).

**SUB-QUESTION 2**

**How does perceived feedback timing relate to reported engagement?**

**Focus:** Examines the relationship between timing and engagement.

**SUB-QUESTION 3**

**What role does peer interaction play in sustaining engagement between tasks?**

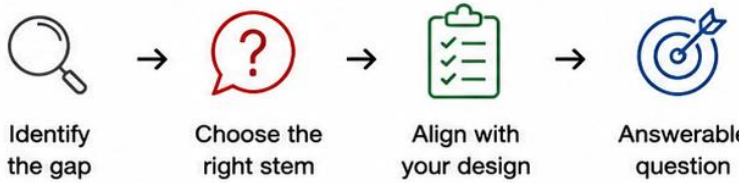
**Focus:** Explores how peer interaction supports ongoing engagement.

- **Covers the whole problem:** Together, the sub-questions must fully answer the main question.
- **Answerable:** Each sub-question must be answerable by data you can realistically obtain.
- **Consistent:** None of them may introduce a variable that never appeared in the problem.

**Tip**

A good set of sub-questions tells a complete story: what is happening, how it relates, and why it matters.

# Question Stems by Type of Design




**PHRASING**

The grammar of your question already signals your design.
Mismatched stems are the first sign of a misaligned proposal.

## Quantitative

**Focus:** Measurement and comparison

- To what extent does X predict Y…
- What is the relationship between…
- Is there a significant difference between…
- How frequently do participants…

Assumes variables that can be measured and compared.

**Example:**
*"To what extent does feedback timing predict student engagement?"*

## Qualitative

**Focus:** Meaning and understanding

- How do participants experience…
- What meanings do X attach to…
- In what ways does X shape…
- Why do participants describe…

Assumes meanings and processes that must be interpreted.

**Example:**
*"How do first-year students experience feedback timing in asynchronous courses?"*

## Mixed methods

**Focus:** Integration of numbers and meanings

- How do measured patterns of X compare with participants' accounts of X…
- To what extent do interview findings explain the survey results…

Requires both strands and an explicit reason for combining them.

**Example:**
*"How do patterns in engagement data compare with students' experiences of peer interaction?"*

**Keep it clear**

- Avoid yes/no questions (not answerable in depth).
- Ask one thing at a time — avoid combining two questions.
- Every question should be answerable with the data you can collect.

# Six Tests for Every Research Question



## QUALITY CONTROL

Use these six tests to check that your question is clear, focused, and researchable.

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | **Answerable with data** | You can name the evidence that would answer it — and imagine obtaining it. | **Example:** Course LMS logs, survey results, interview transcripts. |
| 2 | **Single and specific** | One question per sentence, with a named population and context. | **Example:** First-year students in asynchronous undergraduate courses at Indonesian universities. |
| 3 | **Free of hidden assumptions** | Avoid "why" questions that assume what should be demonstrated. | **Avoid:** "Why is feedback timing important?" **Better:** "How does feedback timing relate to student engagement?" |
| 4 | **Neutral in wording** | The phrasing does not signal the answer you hope to find. | Avoid leading words like "best," "most effective," or "should." |
| 5 | **Consistent with the design** | A "how do they experience" question cannot be answered by a Likert scale alone. | Match the question type with the data and methods you plan to use. |
| 6 | **Traceable to the problem** | Every term in the question appeared earlier in the problem statement. | Keep the same key variables, population, context, and timeframe. |

**Why it matters:** Strong questions lead to sound designs, meaningful data, and credible conclusions.

# From Questions to Objectives




## OBJECTIVES

An objective has the same content as the question, written as an action the study will perform.

### QUESTION

*How does feedback timing relate to engagement in asynchronous first-year courses?*

### OBJECTIVE

*To examine the relationship between feedback timing and engagement among first-year students in asynchronous courses.*

### GENERAL AND SPECIFIC

Most templates ask for one general objective matching the main question, followed by specific objectives matching each sub-question.

Keep the numbering identical so alignment is visible at a glance.

### VERBS THAT WORK

Use action verbs that indicate measurable or observable actions in your study.

- to describe
- to compare
- to examine
- to measure
- to evaluate
- to analyse
- to identify
- to develop
- to test

### VERBS THAT DO NOT WORK

These verbs describe intention, not measurable action. They cannot be demonstrated as achieved.

- to understand
- to know
- to learn about
- to appreciate
- to explore deeply
- to be aware of

### GOOD PRACTICE

- Use the same key terms (variables, population, context, timeframe).
- Keep the focus: what you will do, not what you hope to find.
- Make objectives clear, measurable, and achievable.

# Hypotheses — Only Where They Belong

## HYPOTHESES

Required in most experimental and correlational designs; usually absent in qualitative and purely descriptive studies.




### $H_0$ Null hypothesis ($H_0$)

States that no relationship or difference exists. It is the statement your analysis actually tests.

**EXAMPLE**

*There is no significant relationship between feedback timing and student engagement.*

Your results will show either enough evidence to reject $H_0$, or not.

### $H_1$ Alternative hypothesis ($H_1$)

States the relationship or difference you expect to find, based on theory or prior findings.

**EXAMPLE** (Directional)

*Students receiving feedback within 24 hours report significantly higher engagement.*

**EXAMPLE** (Non-directional)

*Feedback timing differs significantly in its relationship with student engagement.*

### Directional or not

Direction is claimed only when prior evidence justifies it; otherwise state the relationship without a direction.

**EXAMPLE**

*Directional: "higher than".*
*Non-directional: "differs from".*

Do not claim a direction unless you can justify it with prior studies or theory.

**IMPORTANT**

Never write hypotheses simply because the template has a heading for them.
A hypothesis you cannot test is a liability in the defence.

# Scope, Delimitations, and Limitations

## BOUNDARIES

Clear boundaries strengthen your study by focusing what you will do—and what you will not.

**FOCUS**
Define what is included

→

**BOUNDARIES**
Set clear limits

→

**BETTER RESULTS**
Improve relevance and interpretation

| Term | What it means | Where it belongs | Example |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Scope** | The boundaries of the study: who, what, where, and when.<br>Sets the exact coverage of the study. | **Introduction** (early in the report) | First-year students in three asynchronous courses at one university, in one semester. |
| **Delimitations** | The boundaries you choose, together with the reason for each choice.<br>Reflects your decisions and rationale. | **Introduction** (early in the report) | Only asynchronous courses are included, because feedback timing is not comparable in live sessions. |
| **Limitations** | Constraints you cannot control that may affect the findings.<br>Acknowledge what may influence results. | **Methodology**, revisited in the final report | Self-reported engagement may differ from observed engagement. |

**KEY DIFFERENCE:** Delimitations are decisions with reasons; limitations are constraints with consequences.
**Confusing the two suggests you do not know which was which.**

# Significance: Who Benefits, and How

**Research** Finds answers → **Creates value** For others → **Informs action** Or decisions → **Improves outcomes** In practice or policy

## SIGNIFICANCE OF THE STUDY

Explain the value of your study by showing who will benefit and what they will be able to do as a result.

### Theoretical

Extends, tests, or refines an existing account. Name the theory and say what your findings would add to it.

**Who benefits:**
Researchers, scholars

**They will be able to:**
Build stronger theories and advance knowledge.

### Practical

Gives practitioners something they can act on. Name the practitioners.

**Who benefits:**
Practitioners: lecturers, nurses, managers, teachers

**They will be able to:**
Improve practices, solve problems, and work more effectively.

### Policy

Informs a decision that an institution or authority has to make. Name the decision.

**Who benefits:**
Institutions, decision makers, policy authorities

**They will be able to:**
Make evidence-based decisions and allocate resources wisely.

### Methodological

Offers an instrument, adaptation, or procedure others can reuse — claim this only if it is genuinely new.

**Who benefits:**
Researchers, future studies

**They will be able to:**
Use or build on the tool, adaptation, or procedure you developed.

## TEST YOUR CLAIM

Test each claim by finishing this sentence: "Because of this study, _____ will be able to _____."
If you cannot fill both blanks with something specific and meaningful, delete the claim.

**GOOD EXAMPLE**
*"Because of this study, **course designers** will be able to **revise feedback policies** to boost engagement."*

**WEAK EXAMPLE**
*"Because of this study, **people** will be able to **understand** the topic better."*

Be specific about who benefits and what they can do.

# Defining Key Terms

## DEFINITION OF TERMS

Define only the terms that carry weight in your questions — the ones a reader could interpret differently from you.



**Clarify**
Identify terms that need definition

**Conceptual**
Define the meaning in the literature

**Operational**
Specify how it will be observed or measured

**Consistent**
Use the same definition throughout

### CONCEPTUAL DEFINITION

What the term means in the literature, with a citation.

> *"Student engagement refers to the behavioural, emotional, and cognitive investment a student makes in a learning task (Author, Year)."*

**Why it matters**

- Ensures a shared understanding of the term based on existing knowledge.

### OPERATIONAL DEFINITION

How the term will be observed or measured in this study.

> *"In this study, engagement is measured as the score obtained on the twelve-item engagement scale, combined with the number of discussion posts submitted per module."*

**Why it matters**

- Provides a clear, replicable way to measure the term.
- Essential for valid analysis and for others to replicate your study.

**Remember:**

Every variable in a quantitative study needs an operational definition.
**Without one, the methodology cannot be written — or judged.**

**Examples of terms to define:**

Population · Time frame · Measurement · Context

# The Alignment Test

**SELF-CHECK**

Lay your own draft out in this form. If any row breaks, the introduction is not finished.



**Identify the problem** — Start with what needs fixing

**Ask the question** — Turn the problem into a research question

**Set the objective** — State the action the study will take

**Get the answer** — Specify what evidence will answer it

| Problem element<br>What needs to be addressed? | Research question<br>What do we need to find out? | Objective<br>What will the study do? | What would answer it<br>What evidence will answer it? |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Feedback is returned too late to act on** | How does feedback timing relate to engagement? | To examine the relationship between feedback timing and engagement | Reported timing and engagement scores from the same students |
| **Students disengage between tasks** | What role does peer interaction play between tasks? | To describe the role of peer interaction between tasks | Interview accounts and discussion-forum activity |
| **Institutions redesign courses without evidence** | Which element most strongly relates to engagement? | To compare the strength of the two relationships | Comparative analysis of the two sets of results |

**QUICK CHECK**

- Every term in column two appears in column one.
- Objectives use action verbs you can actually do.
- The evidence listed is realistic to obtain.
- If you add a new term anywhere, refine your problem statement.

*Every term in column two must already appear in column one. Anything new means the problem was under-stated.*

# Introduction Checklist

**BEFORE YOU SUBMIT THE DRAFT**

Use this checklist to make sure your introduction is complete, focused, and defensible.

**Review** — Check each element → **Verify** — Ensure it meets the criteria → **Revise** — Strengthen any weak spots → **Submit** — Confident in a strong introduction

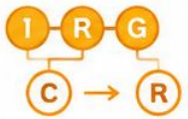
1. **The opening paragraph names the situation and carries a citation.**
   Start broad and establish the context with credible evidence.

2. **Every claim about the state of the world is sourced.**
   Back up each factual statement with a citation from a reliable source.

3. **The background narrows steadily toward the problem.**
   Move from general to specific and end with the immediate issue.

4. **The gap is named as a specific type, not asserted vaguely.**
   Use a clear term (e.g., knowledge gap, evidence gap, practice–outcome gap).

5. **The problem statement contains ideal, reality, gap, consequence, response.**
   All five parts are present and connected in one coherent paragraph.




6. **One main question and two or three sub-questions are stated in one place.**
   They are clear, aligned, and answerable with the planned data.

7. **Objectives mirror the questions, using demonstrable verbs.**
   Each objective states an action the study will actually perform.

8. **Scope, delimitations, significance, and key terms are all present.**
   Each is specific, realistic, and written in the right place.

**Final reminder:** Read the checklist again against a **printed draft**, not on screen. You will find more.

# Five Things to Remember




KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **The introduction turns a topic into a problem**
   Start broad, then focus. Clearly show why the issue matters and needs to be studied.



2. **Evidence, not adjectives, establishes context**
   Facts and data with citations build credibility.
   Avoid opinions without evidence.



3. **Name the gap, and name its type**
   Be specific about what is missing. Use the correct type of gap (e.g., knowledge gap, evidence gap, practice–outcome gap).



4. **Questions must be answerable and aligned**
   Your main question and sub-questions should match the problem and be answerable with the data you plan to collect.



5. **Boundaries protect you**
   Clearly define scope and delimitations to make your study feasible and to set valid expectations for your findings.



**Final reminder:** A strong introduction is focused, evidence-based, and aligned from problem to plan.



Clarity today.
Stronger study tomorrow.




# Thank You

Bring your draft introduction and ten sources to Week 3.

Week 2 of 4 · Research Proposal Writing